

The Salt Line

2026 · 450 words

Every autumn the sea took another six feet of the churchyard, and every autumn my grandmother moved the dead.

She did it at low tide, in a wheelbarrow, with a spade that had belonged to her father. The council had a policy about this and the policy was that it did not happen. So she went out at four in the morning when the policy was asleep.

I was eleven the first time she took me. She handed me the torch and told me to point it at the ground and not at the water, because there was nothing in the water worth seeing and a great deal in it worth not seeing. The cliff edge that year had reached the Pettigrews. She knew them by the stone, and when the stone was gone she knew them by counting paces from the yew.

. . .

What we carried was mostly not bones. It was soil that had been a person long enough ago that the distinction had stopped mattering to everyone but her. She would take three barrow-loads from the seaward edge and tip them in a trench she had dug behind the vestry, and she would say the name

aloud once, and that was the whole ceremony.

I asked her why it mattered, if there was nothing left to move.

She leaned on the spade and looked at me the way she looked at weather coming in.

“Because the sea doesn’t know their names,” she said. “Somebody has to be the one that puts them down somewhere on purpose.”

. . .

She died in March and the ground was too hard to take her that week, so she waited in the chapel with the door propped open, which she would have hated, because of the draught.

I buried her at the back, near the vestry, well inland. Then I went to the edge with the torch and the spade and counted paces from the yew, and I found where the Ainsworths had been in 1954, and I moved what was left of them, and I said the name out loud once.

The tide was coming. It always is. But it had another six feet to go before it got anything that hadn’t been put down on purpose.

